

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

BOOK 10 OF 12

The Window

FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

DEDICATION

For the ones you miss, and for the window you keep lit for them.



Father Lucas



BOOK 10

This book: Grief, memory, loneliness and hope: lighting the window.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **The verse.** Read it slowly, out loud if you can.
2. **The word.** A short reading, about one minute.
3. **The prayer.** Say it as written, or in your own words.
4. **Today.** One small thing to do, a question to answer on the lines, and a box to tick when it's done.

If you miss a morning, don't catch up.
Turn to today's page and begin again.
Keep a pen beside this book and write in it.
These pages are yours.

Book 10 of 12 · Days 276–305

Knot: Peace (grief and hope)

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

My friend,

This is the month I most wanted you to have, and the one I wrote most slowly.

Someone is missing from your house. Maybe since last year, maybe for forty years. The coat on the hook. The voice in the hall. I won't tell you it gets easy. I will tell you it gets company.

This month we do the oldest thing there is. We put a light in the window. We cry without apology. We remember on purpose. We walk, we eat something warm, we ask for a hand. And by the last page, I hope you'll laugh once and not be ashamed.

Mary kept a lamp burning through the longest nights. You'll keep yours with her.

Father Lucas



THE MONTH IN FOUR WEEKS

Week 1. Grief keeps no schedule. We light the window, cry without apology, and sit with what is gone.

Week 2. We remember on purpose: a mother's sorrow, letters to the departed, the cemetery, and thanks said through tears.

Week 3. We come back to life slowly: a song, a walk, something warm to eat, the dark thoughts said aloud.

Week 4. Hope and gladness are allowed. We name the dead, plant a seed, laugh, and keep the window candle.

BOOK 10

THREE PROMISES FOR THE MONTH

I. *I will let the tears come before I look for the words.*

II. *I will say one name out loud every day.*

III. *I will keep one light on, even on the tired nights.*

MY NAME



PSALM OF THE MONTH: 27

Wait for the LORD. Be strong, and let your heart take courage. Yes, wait for the LORD. — Psalm 27:14

The psalm of the light and the long wait.

CONTENTS

DAY 276	The Light in the Window	13
DAY 277	Grief Has No Schedule	17
DAY 278	Their Voice in Your Memory	21
DAY 279	The Sweater in the Closet	25
DAY 280	Cry Without Apology	29
DAY 281	The Day That Is Hard	33
DAY 282	Sit With What Is Gone	37
DAY 283	The Empty Seat at Church	42
DAY 284	A Mother's Sorrow	46
DAY 285	Letters to the Departed	50
DAY 286	What They Would Tell You	54
DAY 287	Gratitude Through Tears	58
DAY 288	The Cemetery Visit	62
DAY 289	Memory as Mercy	66
DAY 290	Others Who Mourn	71

CONTENTS · CONTINUED

DAY 291	Small Gladness	75
DAY 292	A Song They Loved	79
DAY 293	Walk in the Morning	83
DAY 294	Eat Something Warm	87
DAY 295	The Dark Thoughts	91
DAY 296	Reach for a Hand	95
DAY 297	Wait With Hope	100
DAY 298	Names of the Dead	104
DAY 299	A Mass for the Departed	108
DAY 300	Three Hundred Mornings	112
DAY 301	Laugh at a Memory	116
DAY 302	Plant Something	120
DAY 303	Light Does Not Argue With Dark	124
DAY 304	Joy Is Allowed	128
DAY 305	The Window Candle	132



WEEK 1

Grief keeps no schedule

DAYS 276 TO 282

We light the window, cry without apology, and sit with what is gone.



DAY 276

The Light in the Window

The LORD is my light and my salvation. Whom shall I fear? The LORD is the strength of my life. Of whom shall I be afraid?

PSALM 27:1 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. Maybe you buried someone this year. Maybe it was long ago, and the house still hasn't learned how to be quiet. Either way, I won't make it smaller than it is. You don't have to be strong this month. You only have to be here.

This month we do one old, simple thing. We keep a light in the window. It doesn't call them back. It tells the dark that someone is home, and awake, and not alone.

Mary kept a light like that, in a house that was no longer the same. Tonight, so will you.

Lord Jesus, it's morning, and the house is quiet in the wrong way. Here is the one I miss. Here are my hands, which don't know what to do with themselves. Light a small flame in me tonight, the way I will in the window. Not a big one. Just enough to see the next step. Stay in this room with me. Amen.



TODAY

Tonight at dusk, set a lamp or a candle in your window. Say the name of the one you miss, out loud, once. Then let the light do the praying.

☐ DONE

Who am I keeping this light on for?

PSALM

27 — the LORD is my light; the psalm for a house that has gone quiet.



DAY 277

Grief Has No Schedule



For my eyes are on you, LORD, the Lord. I take refuge in you. Don't leave my soul destitute.

PSALM 141:8 (WEB)

Some mornings you're fine. You make the eggs. You answer the phone. Then, in the grocery store, you see his brand of crackers, and you're done for the day.

People will tell you it should be easier by now. They mean well. But grief doesn't keep a calendar, and neither does God. He doesn't glance at the clock when you cry, and he never asks you to be finished by supper.

Today, don't measure. Not how far you've come, not how far is left. Sit where you sit, and let the day be as long as it is.

It's a plain morning, Father, and I don't know what it will ask of me. One hour I'm steady. The next I'm sitting on the pantry floor. You were there for both. Keep me from judging my own tears. When the wave comes, hold me up. When it goes, let me rest. Let today be as big or as small as it needs to be. Amen.



TODAY

Take one thing off today's list, just one, and cross it out in pen. Then sit for five minutes and let the clock move without you.

☐ DONE

What am I measuring myself against, and who told me to?

PSALM

141 — my eyes are on you, do not leave my soul destitute; a short prayer for a soul running low.

278

DAY 278

Their Voice in Your Memory

I cried to you, the LORD. I said, "You are my refuge, my portion in the land of the living."

PSALM 142:5 (WEB)

You're afraid you'll forget the sound of her voice. Many are. You listened to the last voicemail so many times you could say it along with her. Or you never saved one, and that hurts more.

Here is a quiet thing. The voice isn't gone. It lives in you, in the way you hear "Eat something" when you open the refrigerator. You carry them more than you know.

Let it speak today. Don't chase it. Sit still, and the memory will come the way a cat comes, once you stop calling.

Gentle Mother, thank you for the voice I still carry. Help me hear it kindly, and not only on the hard days. Where I can't remember the words, let the love inside them be enough. Where I'm afraid of forgetting, let your memory be bigger than mine. Keep them well, and keep me gentle with myself. Amen.



TODAY

Close your eyes for two minutes. Let one sentence they often said come back to you. Hear it in their voice. Then whisper, "Thank you."

☐ DONE

What did their voice say most often when it was trying to love me?

PSALM

142 — I cried to you; the psalm for the one who cries out in a quiet house.



DAY 279

The Sweater in the Closet



a time to seek, and a time to lose; a time to keep, and a time to cast away;

ECCLESIASTES 3:6 (WEB)

You know the one. It's still on the hanger, and it still smells like him. Everyone has an opinion about when you should give it away. I don't. A sweater keeps the shape of his shoulders, and that's worth keeping.

Eileen kept her husband's cardigan on the back of the kitchen door for a long time. Sal from the corner store asked once, kindly, if he should take it off her hands. She said, "Not yet." He said, "Then not yet."

There is a time to keep and a time to let go. Not yet is allowed. So is someday. You decide, and Mary waits.

Mary, there's a sweater in my closet, and I can't decide what to do about it. Help me stop deciding today. Let it hang as long as it needs to. When the day comes to touch it, be beside me. Keep me from guilt either way, and teach my hands to be tender. Stay with me while I look. Amen.



TODAY

Open the closet. Touch the sweater and hold it a moment. Decide nothing. Close the door gently and say, "Not yet."

☐ DONE

When the time comes, what would be gentle to do with it?

PSALM

3 — a shield around me; a verse as warm as something worn.



DAY 280

Cry Without Apology

Answer me when I call, God of my righteousness. Give me relief from my distress. Have mercy on me, and hear my prayer.

PSALM 4:1 (WEB)

You're sorry for crying. You say sorry to the cashier, to the neighbor, to the dog. Please stop.

Jesus wept at a grave in front of everyone. He knew what he was about to do, and he wept anyway. Think about that. He didn't say, "Be strong." He didn't say, "She's in a better place, so dry your face." He stood there and let his face be wet.

Tears are not a lack of faith. They're what love looks like when it has nowhere to go. God is not embarrassed by them.

Lord Jesus, you wept, so I won't be ashamed to. Here are my tears. There are more of them than I expected, and they come at strange times, in the car, in the cereal aisle. Be near when they come. Wash me quiet. And when I'm done, bring me a glass of water and a little peace. Amen.



TODAY

Sit with your coffee and say nothing for two full minutes. Let the tears come if they want to. Keep a clean handkerchief nearby.

☐ DONE

Who taught me that crying was something to hide?

PSALM

4 — answer me when I call; for the hour when you can only cry and ask to be heard.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Grief comes back in waves, even after a good week. The same tide that knocked you down is still out there. Come back to this page tomorrow, and the sand stays under your feet.



DAY 281

The Day That Is Hard

In all their affliction he was afflicted, and the angel of his presence saved them. In his love and in his pity he redeemed them. He bore them, and carried them all the days of old.

ISAIAH 63:9 (WEB)

Every one of us has a day we dread. The day she was born. The day he died. The day the two of you always drove somewhere for no reason at all.

I have one too. I buried my parents, and I still go quiet when it comes around. I know.

You don't have to do the day well. Cancel anything that asks too much. Eat what you can. Let the day be hard out in the open, and let one person know. Hard days get lighter when somebody else knows they're hard.

It's that day again, Lord. I woke up already tired, and you know why. I won't pretend. Walk beside me from this kitchen to bedtime. Where I forget to eat, remind me. Where I need to be alone, protect me. Where I need a person, send a phone call or a knock at the door. And when the day ends, let me be glad it did. Amen.



TODAY

Say out loud, in your kitchen voice, "I'm tired, and I'm still here." Say it twice. Notice that it's true.

☐ DONE

What small kindness could I let someone give me today?

PSALM

5 — in the morning you hear my voice; for the day you dreaded and woke up inside.



DAY 282

Sit With What Is Gone



But you do see trouble and grief. You consider it to take it into your hand. You help the victim and the fatherless.

PSALM 10:14 (WEB)

You've been busy, haven't you? The cabinets are sorted. The closets are sorted. The television has been talking since six in the morning. It's easier to keep moving than to sit down beside what is gone.

I understand. But a loss is patient. It waits in the quiet. If you never sit with it, it follows you from room to room.

So today, give it a place to sit. Not all day. Just one long, quiet morning, with the coffee going cold beside you. It won't bite. It's only the place where they used to be, asking for company.

I have been running from this silence, Lord. Today I'll stay in it, with you. Let it be a place, not a threat. Whatever rises, a name, a memory, an old regret, let me look at it gently. Be as quiet as I am. Be as near as the walls. Hold what I'm holding, and teach me to hold it with you. Amen.



TODAY

Keep the television and radio off until noon. Let the house be quiet. If a memory comes to visit, let it sit down.

☐ DONE

What have I been filling the house with so I wouldn't hear it?

PSALM

10 — you see trouble and grief; a psalm for staying put.



WEEK 2

Week 2

DAYS 283 TO 289

We remember on purpose: a mother's sorrow, letters to the departed, the cemetery, and thanks said through tears.



DAY 283

The Empty Seat at Church

I was glad when they said to me, "Let's go to the LORD's house!"

PSALM 122:1 (WEB)

You used to go together. Now the end of the pew looks very wide, so some mornings you stay home. I understand. Walking in alone can feel like walking onto a stage.

Mrs. Doyle has cleaned our church for twenty years. Last winter a widow stopped coming. Mrs. Doyle knocked on her door with a dish of rice pudding and said only, "I dusted your seat. Come when you can." The widow came back that week.

Your seat is still yours. Nobody wants it but you. And if you aren't ready, Mary will sit with you at home.

Our Lady, there's a seat I can't look at. Give me courage to sit near it, or beside it, or a few rows away, whatever I can bear. Let someone smile at me without asking questions. Let the singing carry me when my own voice won't. I don't have to be strong in your house. Be there before I arrive. Amen.



TODAY

Step outside and say good morning to the first person you see. Grief hides indoors, and a hello is a small way back to people.

☐ DONE

Who in my life would be glad if I simply showed up?

PSALM

122 — I was glad when they said, "Let's go"; for the first walk back through a familiar door. (Changed from 11: Psalm 122:1 fits the empty seat better.)

284

DAY 284

A Mother's Sorrow

Please let your loving kindness be for my comfort, according to your word to your servant. Let your tender mercies come to me, that I may live; for your law is my delight.

PSALM 119:76-77 (WEB)

There's no word in English for a parent who loses a child. We have "widow" and "orphan," but for this we have only silence. I think it's because the thing is too big for a word.

If this is your sorrow, I won't say I understand. I won't say anything clever. I'll say that Mary stood where you are standing, and she didn't understand either. She stayed.

You don't have to be quiet. You may only need to be held for a while, like a little one, by someone who doesn't ask why.

Mary, you know what it is to lose a Son. I lost my child, and I carry the name, and nobody says it anymore. Say it with me. Hold what I cannot hold. Let me rest like a little one who has stopped asking why. Keep my child safe in your Son's arms, and keep me from drowning in the long hours between. Amen.



TODAY

Say today's prayer once more, looking at a photograph of your child. At the end, say the name out loud. Let it be heard in the room.

☐ DONE

Who still says their name, and who could I ask to?

PSALM

131 — like a weaned child with his mother; a psalm for the parent who cannot be consoled. (Changed from 12.)

285

DAY 285

Letters to the Departed

For if we live, we live to the Lord. Or if we die, we die to the Lord. If therefore we live or die, we are the Lord's.

ROMANS 14:8 (WEB)

You still have things to say. The thing about the car. The thing you never thanked her for. The news about the grandchildren. Where do those words go?

They go on paper. A letter to the dead is not foolish. It's how the heart sends the mail it didn't finish. You don't need a stamp. You don't need to know where they are, only that God does.

Write it like you'd talk across the table. Short sentences. The plain truth. Leave out the speeches. They knew you well enough not to need one.

I have a letter in me and no address, Lord. You know where they are. Carry what I write the way a good mailman carries it, unopened, straight to the right door. Let me say the thing I never said. Let me forgive what I need to forgive, and be forgiven in return. Then give me a quiet night. Amen.



TODAY

Write a short letter to the one you miss. Begin with "I wanted you to know." Fold it and keep it in your Bible or beside your bed.

☐ DONE

What is the first thing I would say if they walked in?

PSALM

121 — he keeps your going out and your coming in; a psalm for the one who still sets out each day.



DAY 286

What They Would Tell You

But I trust in your loving kindness. My heart rejoices in your salvation. I will sing to the LORD, because he has been good to me.

PSALM 13:5–6 (WEB)

You know them better than anyone. So you know what they'd say if they could see you this morning.

Walt ushered at our church for years. When his wife died, I asked him, "What would she tell you?" He laughed out loud. "Wipe your feet and eat something." He did both, and by the end of the week he looked better.

That's what a good marriage leaves behind, and a good friendship, and a good mother. A voice that still gives sensible orders. Hear yours today. Then take its advice.

Father, thank you for the people who knew how to love me out loud. I can almost hear what they'd say about the way I'm living now. Give me ears for it. Where they'd scold me, let it be gentle. Where they'd cheer, let me believe it. Help me take one piece of their good sense today. Amen.



TODAY

Write one sentence in their words: what they would tell you to do this morning. Put it where you'll see it all day.

☐ DONE

Which of their sayings do I most need to hear again?

PSALM

13 — I trust in your loving kindness; trust that outlasts a long season of asking how long.

287

DAY 287

Gratitude Through Tears

Those who sow in tears will reap in joy. He who goes out weeping, carrying seed for sowing, will certainly come again with joy, carrying his sheaves.

PSALM 126:5–6 (WEB)

It feels wrong to say thank you in the middle of this. And yet it's there, under the grief, small and stubborn. You're sad because you were given someone worth missing.

That's not a trick of the mind. It's the truth underneath the pain. You can cry and be grateful in the same minute. Both are true, and neither cancels the other. Thanks doesn't mean you're done grieving. It only means you're still loving.

Mary sang her thanks before she knew how the story would end. Borrow some of her courage this morning.

I'm crying and I'm thankful, Lord, and I don't know how both fit in one heart. Thank you for the years. Thank you for the small, ordinary things: the way they said my name, the way they left the hall light on. Let my thanks be honest, and let my tears be honest. Keep both safe in your hand. Amen.



TODAY

Say "thank you" out loud to three things in the room that remind you of them. Let your voice shake if it wants to.

☐ DONE

What ordinary thing about them am I most thankful for?

PSALM

126 — those who sow in tears will reap in joy; a psalm for thanks that arrives wet. (Changed from 24.)

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Mary never tires of you, but it's easy to forget she's in the room. Thank her once today, out loud, and she'll be right where you left her tomorrow. The thread stays loose in hands that keep touching it.



DAY 288

The Cemetery Visit

For he has not despised nor abhorred the affliction of the afflicted, neither has he hidden his face from him; but when he cried to him, he heard.

PSALM 22:24 (WEB)

A cemetery is a strange place to love someone. Some people go every week. Some haven't gone once. Both are all right. There's no wrong way to stand there.

If you go today, you don't need to say anything holy. Bring them a little news. The weather. The grandchildren. The silly thing the neighbor did. Talk the way you talked across the table.

If you can't go, that's all right too. Step outside, face the direction where they rest, and speak from your own doorstep. Love travels better than you do.

They're in the ground, and I'm up here, Lord, and the distance is too small and too great at the same time. Bless this place and every name in it. Let me stand here without fear. Let the quiet be company. Keep their rest sweet and my steps steady, and take me home with my heart a little lighter. Amen.



TODAY

Go to the grave if you can, and tell them one piece of news. If you can't, stand on your doorstep, face their way, and tell them from there.

☐ DONE

What news would they most want to hear from me?

PSALM

22 — he has not hidden his face; for a visit that asks only that you show up.



DAY 289

Memory as Mercy

Surely goodness and loving kindness shall follow me all the days of my life, and I will dwell in the LORD's house forever.

PSALM 23:6 (WEB)

At first every memory cuts. A song, a smell, a joke you can't tell anymore. You wonder why God left you the memories at all, if all they do is hurt.

I wonder if they're mercy. The same memories that hurt today will warm you someday. They're like a hand laid on your back by someone you can't see.

Goodness follows you, says the psalm. Not ahead of you. Behind you, close, all the days of your life. Some of it follows in the shape of a memory. Let it catch up with you.

Gentle God, thank you that my love left a trail. Let me walk back along it without being afraid. When a memory comes at me sharp, soften it before it lands. When one comes warm, let me stay a moment longer. I give you the good days I had, and I ask you to keep them safe where time can't reach. Amen.



TODAY

Write today's date and one good memory of them in a single line. Keep it where you'll find it on a hard day.

☐ DONE

Which memory has stopped hurting and started to warm me?

PSALM

23 — goodness and loving kindness will follow me; memory as company, walking behind you.



WEEK 3

Week 3

DAYS 290 TO 296

We come back to life slowly: a song, a walk, something warm to eat, the dark thoughts said aloud.



DAY 290

Others Who Mourn

Rejoice with those who rejoice.
Weep with those who weep.

ROMANS 12:15 (WEB)

You are not the only one in your family who misses them. It can feel that way. Everyone grieves in a separate corner, and nobody knows how to knock.

Marguerite sings in our choir. When her sister died, she called her sister's husband, a man she hardly knew. They didn't talk about the sadness. They talked about her sister's terrible cooking, and they laughed until they cried. Both said it was the first good hour in weeks.

Someone near you is waiting for a call like that. Be the one who makes it, even if it is short.

Holy Mother, I thought I was grieving alone, and I wasn't. Show me who else misses them. Give me a few words that aren't clumsy, or give me the courage to be clumsy anyway. Let a short call turn into a long one. Let two sad people be a little less sad. And if no one answers, keep me from taking it to heart. Amen.



TODAY

Call one person who also loved them. Don't plan what to say. Ask, "How are you, really?" Then listen, and say their name once.

☐ DONE

Who else is carrying this, and carrying it quietly?

PSALM

28 — the LORD is my strength and my shield; hands lifted for those who mourn beside us.



DAY 291

Small Gladness

The LORD will give strength to his people. The LORD will bless his people with peace.

PSALM 29:11 (WEB)

Today I want to talk about the sun on the kitchen floor.

A small gladness walked in this morning, and you almost didn't notice. The sparrow at the feeder. The coffee that came out just right. A sentence on the radio that made you smile before you remembered. Then you felt guilty, as if you'd been caught at something, and you put your face back on.

You haven't been caught. Gladness is not betrayal. It's the light making one small square in a dark room. Let it stay as long as it likes. They would want you to have it.

A small joy found me today, Lord, and I almost sent it away. Teach me to receive it without guilt. Let me say, "That was good," and not hear a scolding afterward. Keep my heart wide enough for sorrow and for the sparrow at the same time. Thank you for every little light you slip into my day. Amen.



TODAY

Notice one small good thing today: the sun, a bird, a warm cup. Smile at it on purpose and say quietly, "That was good."

☐ DONE

What small gladness came to me today that I almost sent away?

PSALM

29 — the LORD will bless his people with peace; a verse small enough to keep in a pocket.



DAY 292

A Song They Loved

I will bless the LORD at all times. His praise will always be in my mouth. My soul shall boast in the LORD. The humble shall hear of it and be glad.

PSALM 34:1–2 (WEB)

There's a song. You know the one. They hummed it at the sink. It came on in the car, and you pulled over. Now you turn the radio off the moment it starts.

I'd like you to try the opposite, just once. Let the song play all the way through. The first minute will hurt. After that, something in you shifts and loosens. A song is a door that opens only one way, into the room where they're still alive and singing off-key.

Go in. Stay as long as you like. Mary will wait right here.

Jesus, give me the song. Give me the part of it I can bear, and then the rest. Let it carry me back to the kitchen where they sang, and let me sing a bar or two beside them. Where my voice cracks, let that be the harmony. And when the last note fades, leave me with more thanks than tears. Amen.



TODAY

Play or hum the song they loved, all the way through. Keep one hand on your heart. If you only get through half, that counts.

☐ DONE

What did that song mean to them, and what does it mean to me?

PSALM

34 — I will bless the LORD at all times; the psalm of a mouth that still has a song in it.



DAY 293

Walk in the Morning



Your word is a lamp to my feet,
and a light for my path.

PSALM 119:105 (WEB)

Your body has been in mourning too. The shoulders are up around your ears. The legs haven't been asked to do much. The house has begun to feel like a very small world.

So go out in the morning. Walk slowly. A grieving heart often thinks better on its feet. The street doesn't need your story. It only needs you to pass through it.

The psalmist said the word is a lamp to the feet and a light for the path. That's a walking verse. Try it between the mailboxes.

I'm going out, Lord, and I'm not sure my legs will agree. Walk with me. Let the air do its small work. At every corner I'll say one Hail Mary, and you can finish what I can't. Let the people I pass be kind, and let me be kind back. Bring me home with a little more breath in me than I left with. Amen.



TODAY

Walk once around the block and say one Hail Mary at each corner. Go slowly. If you can't walk far, do it at your front door.

☐ DONE

What does my body need that I've been too sad to give it?

PSALM

42 — hope in God; a psalm that talks to the soul out loud while walking.



DAY 294

Eat Something Warm

Oh, send out your light and your truth. Let them lead me. Let them bring me to your holy hill, to your tents.

PSALM 43:3 (WEB)

You've been living on toast and crackers, or on nothing. I know, because I did it. Cooking for one feels silly. The pot is too big. The smell reminds you who used to eat it.

After her husband died, Eileen ate standing at the counter for a month. Sal from the corner store sent over a small pot of soup with a note that said, "Sit down." She sat down. She ate the soup. She said it tasted like being looked after.

Grief is hard work, and hard work needs fuel.

Lord Jesus, you made breakfast for tired friends on the shore. Make me a little hungry today, and give me the strength to heat something and sit down with it. Let each spoonful say I'm still worth looking after. Bless the hands that grew it, and bless the ones I miss, who once set it in front of me. Amen.



TODAY

Warm something real: soup, eggs, oatmeal. Put it on a plate or in a bowl, and sit down to eat it, with a napkin, as if company were coming.

☐ DONE

When did I last treat myself the way I'd treat a guest?

PSALM

43 — send out your light; warm, plain, and enough for the next step.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Today's strength is for today. You can't eat once and be full all week, and you can't pray once and be at peace all month. Come back tomorrow, and pull up a chair.



DAY 295

The Dark Thoughts

The LORD is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves those who have a crushed spirit.

PSALM 34:18 (WEB)

Some nights the thoughts get dark. "What's the point." "I'd rather be with them." Many who mourn have thought it, and many never say it out loud. I won't scold you. It doesn't make you faithless. It makes you tired.

But don't carry it alone. Tell a living person today: your doctor, a friend, your priest. If the thoughts turn to ending your life, call or text 988 right now, any hour.

You don't have to feel better to ask for help. Asking is the first strong thing you can do.

Lord, you hold me even when my own thoughts go dark. I'm so tired. I don't want to keep feeling this way. Hear me. Send me someone to tell, and give me the nerve to say it plainly. Keep me safe through this hour and the next one. Don't let me be alone with it. I believe you're here, even when I can't feel it. Amen.



TODAY

Say to one living person, in your own words, "This has been a dark week for me." Say only that. Let them answer.

☐ DONE

Who is the safest person to tell the truth to today?

PSALM

94 — your comforts delight my soul; for the hour when thoughts run faster than you do. (Changed from 44.)



DAY 296

Reach for a Hand



God is our refuge and strength,
a very present help in trouble.

PSALM 46:1 (WEB)

You're good at giving. You've been giving all your life. Asking is a different muscle, and right now it's weak. That's all right. Muscles come back.

Here's what I've learned from sitting at too many kitchen tables. People want to help the grieving. They just don't know how, so they wait to be told. Say it plainly. "Could you drive me to the store?" "Could you sit with me an hour?"

Accepting help isn't weakness. It's letting someone be the hands of Christ for one morning. Let them. They may need to give as much as you need to take.

I'm not good at asking, Lord. My pride comes up like a wall. Soften it today. Show me one person I can lean on and one small thing I can ask. Give them a kind heart and a free afternoon. And when I'm helped, let me say thank you without apologizing. You send hands, Lord. Let me take hold of one. Amen.



TODAY

Call one person and ask for one small, plain favor: a ride, a visit, a hand with a heavy jar. Then say thank you.

☐ DONE

What have I been carrying alone that someone else could lift?

PSALM

46 — a very present help in trouble; the psalm for the one who has to ask.



WEEK 4

Hope and gladness are allowed

DAYS 297 TO 305

We name the dead, plant a seed, laugh, and keep the window candle.



DAY 297

Wait With Hope

Be strong, and let your heart take courage, all you who hope in the LORD.

PSALM 31:24 (WEB)

Tom lives next door to me. He's a widower. Last winter I noticed his kitchen light coming on at five every morning. I asked him why so early. He said, "She always got up first and put the coffee on. So I get up and put it on for her."

He didn't say it sadly. He said it like a man keeping his post.

That's hope in its plain clothes. You keep the habit until the morning makes sense again. Hope doesn't shout. It waits with the light on. That's all it asks of you today.

Mary, I don't know what I'm waiting for. A better day. A sign. The end of this feeling. Teach me to wait without clenching my fists. Keep my small habits steady while my heart finds its feet. Let the light in my window burn even when I'm too tired to believe in it. I wait for you, quietly. Amen.



TODAY

Breathe out the word "Mary" ten times, slowly. Between breaths, wait a moment, as if listening for an answer. Let the quiet answer if it wants to.

☐ DONE

What small habit of theirs am I keeping alive, and why?

PSALM

31 — be strong, all you who hope in the LORD; waiting as an act, not a pause.



DAY 298

Names of the Dead

For he will never be shaken. The righteous will be remembered forever. He will not be afraid of evil news. His heart is steadfast, trusting in the LORD.

PSALM 112:6–7 (WEB)

On your Names Page you've written the living, the ones you pray for. Today we make room for the others.

The Church has always said the names of the dead. At the table. At the grave. In the quiet before a meal. It's one of the oldest kindnesses we have. A name spoken aloud is a candle lit in the dark.

Say all of them. The ones you knew well and the ones you barely knew. Parents, friends, a neighbor, a child. Don't leave one out because it still hurts. Someone is remembering each of them, and today it's you.

Father, here are my dead, and I name them to you one by one. Receive them. Give them rest, and let light shine on them without end. Where I owe them thanks, let it reach them. Where I owe them an apology, let it reach them, too. Keep us joined in you, close, in the way only you know how. Amen.



TODAY

Say the names of your dead out loud, slowly, one by one. After each name, say "Rest in peace," or simply breathe.

☐ DONE

Which name have I stopped saying aloud, and why?

PSALM

112 — remembered forever; for the names you won't let go quiet. (Changed from 53.)



DAY 299

A Mass for the Departed



Precious in the LORD's sight is the death of his saints.

PSALM 116:15 (WEB)

There's an old and beautiful custom. You ask the parish to remember your dead at Mass, by name. The priest says it at the altar, and the whole church prays for them while you sit there, not needing to say a word.

I've done this for my own parents. I'll tell you honestly: it's the closest thing I know to a hug that crosses a wall.

You don't have to explain anything. Walk to the church office, or the rectory door, and give the name. Ask for a day. The rest is theirs to carry.

Lord Jesus, receive the name I bring to your table. Let it be spoken aloud in your house, and let it be heard in the place where they are. Give them peace and a welcome. Be gentle with them. Give me the peace of knowing I didn't let them go quiet. I put it in your hands, and in the hands of your whole Church. Amen.



TODAY

Stop by the church or the rectory today and ask to have one name remembered at Mass. Give the name and a day. Then go home.

☐ DONE

Whose name has gone longest without being spoken at Mass?

PSALM

116 — precious in the LORD's sight; a short verse said beside graves. (Changed from 54.)



DAY 300

Three Hundred Mornings

He has swallowed up death forever! The Lord the LORD will wipe away tears from off all faces. He will take the reproach of his people away from off all the earth, for the LORD has spoken it.

ISAIAH 25:8 (WEB)

Three hundred mornings. Let that number sit a minute. It's a long road, and you've walked it. You've shown up when it rained inside you and when it didn't. On the days you were angry. On the days you didn't believe a word. You came anyway.

Look back, but gently. Maybe the nights are shorter. Maybe a phone rang that hadn't rung in years. Maybe nothing changed, except you're still standing, and that is not nothing.

Isaiah says God will wipe the tears from every face. Not one of your mornings has been wasted.

Mary, three hundred mornings, and here I am again. Thank you for every one. Thank you for the nights I couldn't pray and you prayed for me. Keep what has been loosened, loose. Keep my feet on this road. Take the name I carry today, and hold it in the light with all the others. I light this flame, and I rest. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle for the one you miss most. Say the name aloud. Watch the flame for one full minute.

☐ DONE

What has quietly changed in me since the first morning?

PSALM

56 — you count my wanderings and keep my tears; for the long road and the God who keeps the record.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I let it slip once. I skipped a few mornings, then a few weeks, and the knot I'd loosened pulled tight again. Come back tomorrow. Three hundred is a good number to keep adding to.



DAY 301

Laugh at a Memory

> *a time to weep, and a time to laugh; a time to mourn, and a time to dance;*
>
> ECCLESIASTES 3:4 (WEB)

Walt told me about the pot roast. His wife made it every week, and every week it was a little tough. He never said a word. At her funeral he stood up and said, "Best worst pot roast in the county." The whole church laughed, wet faces and all, for a full minute.

Laughing at a memory isn't disrespect. It's the memory finally breathing. Somewhere there's a story about them that always got a laugh. Tell it. It will feel strange at first. Then it will feel like their company.

Thank you for the laughter we shared, Lord, and for the things that were funny only to us. Let me remember them without guilt. If I laugh and then cry, let that be all right. Let the old jokes live a little longer in my mouth. And when I'm alone and smile at nothing, let me know it's you, smiling back. Amen.



TODAY

Tell one funny story about them out loud, to a person or to the room. Let yourself laugh at the end, even if it wobbles.

☐ DONE

What was the funniest thing about the way they lived?

PSALM

126 — our mouth was filled with laughter; a verse that allows tears and laughter in one breath.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

What you skip one day, you skip two. Laughter fades if nobody feeds it. Come back tomorrow, without guilt, and tell the next story. Small steps keep the thread loose.



DAY 302

Plant Something

They are planted in the LORD's house. They will flourish in our God's courts. They will still produce fruit in old age. They will be full of sap and green,

PSALM 92:13–14 (WEB)

Nothing in the ground cares about your age. A seed doesn't ask if you're too tired, too old, or too sad. It needs a little dirt, some water, and a window.

Planting something tells the future you plan to be here. It's a small act of hope, done with your hands. And when the green shows up, it will feel like a little answer to a big question. Water it a little each morning.

You don't need a garden. You need a glass, a damp paper towel, and something that wants to grow.

Lord of the green things, I put this little seed in your hands. I don't know what it will become. Neither do I know what I'll become. Water us both. Let me check on it each morning with a bit of curiosity. Let its first leaf be a quiet reminder that you aren't finished with me. Amen.



TODAY

Put a bean, an avocado pit, or a kitchen sprig in a glass of water on the windowsill. Say, "Grow." Check it tomorrow.

☐ DONE

What in me is still wanting to grow, even now?

PSALM

92 — still bearing fruit in old age; the psalm for planting at any age. (Changed from 59.)



DAY 303

Light Does Not Argue With Dark

Again, therefore, Jesus spoke to them, saying, "I am the light of the world. He who follows me will not walk in the darkness, but will have the light of life."

JOHN 8:12 (WEB)

A candle doesn't fight the dark. It just burns. It doesn't have to win an argument. The dark has no answer for a small flame.

Think of the women who went to the tomb at dawn, carrying spices for someone they'd lost. They didn't argue with the dark. They kept walking toward the place they feared. And they found it open and empty.

That's courage. Small steps toward the place that hurts, carrying what you have, even if it's only a lamp and a tired heart. Keep walking. The light has a way of getting there first.

Jesus, light of the world, I'm not asking you to win the argument with my sadness. I'm asking you to be the light in the room while I'm in it. Let a small flame be enough. Let my darkness have no last word. Show me the next step, and let me take it. Stay until I can see. I'll wait quietly with you. Amen.



TODAY

Look out a window for one full minute with your phone in another room. Watch where the light falls, on the floor or on your hands, and say nothing.

☐ DONE

Where in my day does the light already fall, even a little?

PSALM

62 — wait in silence for God alone; patience to hold the dark and the light in one hour.



DAY 304

Joy Is Allowed

Our soul has waited for the LORD. He is our help and our shield. For our heart rejoices in him, because we have trusted in his holy name.

PSALM 33:20–21 (WEB)

Mrs. Doyle polishes the pews and hums while she does it. When her husband died, she stopped humming for a month. Then one afternoon I heard it again, faint, from the back of the church. I didn't say a word. Neither did she. She just kept polishing, and I let her.

Joy comes back like that. Not with a trumpet. With a hum.

You may think joy is over for you. It isn't. It's allowed. God doesn't keep a ledger of how long you've been sad. He just keeps the door open for you.

Father, I'm afraid of being happy again. It feels like leaving them behind. Tell my heart it isn't so. Let me enjoy a good meal, a good song, a child's laugh, without guilt. Let joy walk beside my sadness like two old friends. Thank you for the gladness you're saving for me. I'm making room for it. Amen.



TODAY

Turn your face toward a sunny spot or a lamp for one full minute. Let your shoulders drop, and let yourself enjoy it.

☐ DONE

What would I enjoy today if I stopped asking permission?

PSALM

33 — our heart rejoices in him; a psalm that gives joy a seat at the table.



DAY 305

The Window Candle

If I say, "Surely the darkness will overwhelm me. The light around me will be night," even the darkness doesn't hide from you, but the night shines as the day. The darkness is like light to you.

PSALM 139:11-12 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. Tonight we finish what we started. Put a light in the window, and leave it on as long as you're awake. It says: someone here remembers. Someone here hopes.

The light isn't for them. They're in a better light than any lamp. It's for you, and for whoever walks by in the dark and sees a house that hasn't given up.

Thirty mornings ago this house felt like a tomb. Look at it now. The grief is still here, but it has air in it, and a light on it.

Mary, Undoer of Knots, here is my window, and here is my light. I lit it for the one I miss and for the one I'm becoming. Keep the flame when I forget. Keep me kind to my own sorrow. Take every name I carry into your arms. And when morning comes, let me wake to the light that never needed a lamp. Amen.



TODAY

At dusk, set a candle or a lamp in the window and say the name you miss. Leave it burning until you go to bed.

☐ DONE

Who will see this light and know they are not alone?

PSALM

63 — my soul stays close to you; the psalm for the window at the end of a long month.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

What opened this month won't shut by itself, but a window left open can be forgotten, and the cold gets in. Check it each morning. A knot untied can be tied again.



THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

Book 10 of 12

NEXT · BOOK 11 · OPEN HANDS